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Chapter 8. Remoting into machines from a phone

The payoff of this chapter: open a terminal on your Pi, or a full graphical desktop on a laptop, straight from a phone, anywhere, by typing the machine's name. No IP addresses, no port forwarding, just the Tailscale name.

By now everything on your tailnet is reachable by name. This chapter puts that to work from a phone. Two tools cover the two common jobs:

Tool	What it gives you	Good for
Termius	An SSH terminal (command line)	The headless Pi, or any server
NoMachine	A full remote desktop (mouse, windows)	A machine that has a GUI (your laptop/desktop)

The Pi has no desktop, so you reach it with **Termius** (SSH). When you want to click around a real desktop from a phone, that's **NoMachine**, pointed at a machine that runs one.

💡 Name your machines first, it makes all of this painless

Everything below addresses machines by their **Tailscale name**, so before anything else, give each device a clear, memorable name. In the Tailscale admin console (<https://login.tailscale.com>) open the **Machines** page, and for each device use the menu and **Edit machine name** to set something obvious like **homelab**, **laptop**, or **desktop**. With MagicDNS on (Chapter 1), every device on your tailnet can then reach each one by that bare name. Vague auto-generated names like **desktop-3f2a** are the thing that makes remote access annoying; fix that once here.

Part A. SSH from a phone with Termius

Termius is a free SSH client for iOS and Android. Because the phone runs Tailscale, it resolves your machine names directly, so you connect to **homelab** exactly like you would from your laptop.

Step 1: Confirm the phone is on the tailnet

Open the **Tailscale** app on the phone and make sure it's connected (this was set up in Chapter 1). That's what lets **homelab** resolve. On cellular or any Wi-Fi, the name resolves over the tailnet.

Step 2: Install Termius and add the Pi as a host

Install **Termius** from the App Store or Play Store, then add a new host:

- **Hostname / Address:** the Tailscale name of the machine, e.g. **homelab** (or its full name **homelab.your-tailnet.ts.net**, or the **100.x.y.z** Tailscale IP if a bare name ever doesn't resolve).
- **Username:** your account on that machine (the one you use for **ssh you@homelab**).
- **Port:** 22.

Step 3: Authenticate with an SSH key

Your Pi only accepts **key-based** login (Chapter 1), so Termius needs a key it trusts. Two easy ways:

- **Generate a key in Termius** (Keychain → new key), copy its **public** key, and append it to the Pi's **~/.ssh/authorized_keys** from a machine that's already logged in:

```
echo 'ssh-ed25519 AAAA... (the public key Termius shows you)' >>
~/.ssh/authorized_keys
```

- **Or import the key you already use** from your laptop into Termius's Keychain, since that key is already authorized on the Pi.

Attach the key to the host, tap to connect, and you have a terminal on the Pi from the phone. From here you can run **docker compose**, check logs, restart a service, anything you'd do over SSH at your desk.

Part B. A full desktop with NoMachine

Sometimes you want a real **graphical desktop**, not a terminal: a browser, a file manager, a GUI app. **NoMachine** streams a machine's desktop to a phone, fast enough to use. It needs a machine that **has** a desktop, so this is for your **Linux laptop or desktop**, not the headless Pi.

Step 4: Install the NoMachine server on the GUI machine

On the machine whose desktop you want to reach (your laptop/desktop), download the NoMachine package for your system from <https://www.nomachine.com/download> and install it. On Debian/Ubuntu that's the **.deb**:

```
sudo dpkg -i nomachine_*.deb      # then, if it complains about deps:
sudo apt --fix-broken install
```

Installing it starts the NoMachine **server**, which listens on port **4000**. No router ports are needed: the phone reaches it over Tailscale.

 **Keep NoMachine on the tailnet only**

Don't port-forward 4000 from your router. NoMachine should be reachable **only** over your tailnet (and your LAN), exactly like everything else in this series. The Tailscale tunnel is already encrypted; NoMachine adds its own login on top.

Step 5: Connect from the phone by name

Install the **NoMachine** app on the phone, then add a connection:

- **Host:** the machine's Tailscale name, e.g. **desktop** (or its **100.x.y.z**).
- **Port:** 4000.
- **Protocol:** NX.

Log in with that machine's normal user account, and its desktop appears on your phone, controllable by touch. The machine needs to be **on, awake, and logged in to a desktop session** for this to work. When you only need the command line, or you're reaching the Pi, use Termius from Part A instead.

Recap

- **Name every machine** clearly on the Tailscale Machines page so the rest is just typing a name.
- **Termius** gives you an SSH terminal from a phone, addressed by Tailscale name, with key auth, the right tool for the headless Pi.
- **NoMachine** gives you a full remote desktop from a phone, for machines that run a desktop, over the tailnet with nothing exposed to the internet.